OBOR would seek to reduce poverty around Asia and the world. Since then, OBOR's envisioned reach has spread to Africa and Latin America, along with projected Maritime and Ice Silk Roads.

Despite widespread suspicion that the amounts ultimately invested in the OBOR would be significantly less than promised, Xi's scheme nonetheless sparked initial eagerness in countries like Pakistan and Malaysia, but backlash in other parts of Asia and beyond as previous and potential recipient nations balked at getting ensnared in what some called "debt-trap diplomacy." When Sri Lanka was forced in 2017 to hand over a strategic port to Chinese control due to its inability to repay debts, tighter economic integration with Beijing suddenly appeared as much a risk as a boon for cash-starved nations. Malaysia successfully reduced by one-third the loan amount for a rail line due to fears of strategic indebtedness to Beijing, while the Maldives, Sri Lanka, and even Pakistan were among the countries exploring stepping back from commitments to receive Chinese aid.[17] As a linchpin in Beijing's strategy, the hesitance of Islamabad to continue with some high-profile infrastructure projects was a particularly noteworthy shift in regional opinion.[18]

Functioning as a quasi-trade agreement, the OBOR also highlights the free-trade competition between Tokyo and Beijing. Despite what many consider a timid and sluggish Japanese trade policy, Japanese economist Kiyoshi Kojima had proposed a Free Trade Area of the Asia-Pacific as far back as 1966, although the idea was not taken seriously until the first decade of the 2000s, by the Asia-Pacific Economic Cooperation (APEC) forum. In 2003, Japan and the ten-member Association of Southeast Asian Nations (ASEAN) began negotiating a free-trade agreement, which came into effect in 2008.

Japan's major free-trade push came with the Trans-Pacific Partnership (TPP), which it formally joined in 2013. Linking Japan with the United States and ten other Pacific nations, the TPP would have accounted for nearly 40 percent of global output and fully a quarter of global trade. After the United States withdrew from the TPP in January